

Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 12



CHAPTER 12



DOWN TO THE SEA

Nat got up tiredder than he had gone to bed, and still without an answer to his questions. What should he do with his venture? Try to take it back to the man who sold him the shoes? Try to send it on another ship? Ask Mr. Derby if he could send his venture on the *Henry*?

At ten that morning a message called him to Mr. Derby's office. When Nat got there he found Mr. Derby talking to a tall, sturdy man with bold, black eyes — Captain Henry Prince. Nat smiled when he saw Prince. He remembered the times the captain had been in the chandlery. When Captain Prince laughed he rattled the instruments on the shelves!

What a difference, Nat thought, between Mr. Derby and the men who commanded his ships. The Derby captains walked with a swagger and roared commands. Mr. Derby was cool and quiet. Men said Elias Derby could see around corners and guess what was coming next. A man of ideas — Mr. Derby — who knew how to pick the men to carry out his ideas.

“Nathaniel,” said Mr. Derby, “Captain Prince is commanding a ship of mine — the *Henry* — on a voyage to Bourbon. He agrees with me that you’d make an excellent clerk.”

Just like that! Not a word about the trouble with Gibaut! Nat tried to sound as cool and collected as Mr. Derby. "I'd like to ship as clerk under Captain Prince, sir."

"Clerk — and second mate," Prince growled. "I never carry idlers on my ship! Between ports, a clerk isn't worth the hardtack to keep him alive." He turned to Mr. Derby. "Anything else, sir?"

Mr. Derby leaned back and matched his finger tips. "Just this, Captain Prince — which I tell all my masters — every time they sail. When you're off soundings, you're on your own. I've given you suggestions for trading when you reach Bourbon. But when you get there, you may find my suggestions aren't worth the paper they're written on. You'll use your own judgment. There are only two things I expressly forbid. You'll never break a law of any port you enter. And you'll never — *never* enter into slave trade." He leaned forward, gripping the arms of his chair. "I'd rather lose any ship I own than to have it become a slaver! There is no excuse that I'd accept. Even if a slaver attacked you, overpowered you, and ordered you to carry a cargo of slaves — even that would be no excuse! You'd go down

fighting — but you wouldn't turn a Derby ship into a slaver!"

Before Nat realized what he was doing, he clapped his hands. "Good for you!" Captain Prince stared at him. He felt his face get hot.

A frosty twinkle touched Mr. Derby's eyes. "I'm glad we agree, Nathaniel." He stood. "Well, gentlemen, I believe that is all."

Captain Prince and Nat left the office together. Prince clapped his hand on Nat's shoulder. "Glad you're sailing with me, Nat."

Nat explained about his venture. "It's a pretty sizable bit of cargo, sir. I invested nearly all the money I have in it — almost a hundred and thirty-five dollars."

"A hundred and . . ." Prince chuckled. "Don't worry, Nat. There's plenty of room for your venture. A hundred and thirty-five dollars . . ." Still chuckling, he waved good-by and strode off.

Nat didn't see the captain again until the raw January morning when the *Henry* was ready to sail. He was waiting on deck with the rest of the crew when he saw Captain Prince striding along the wharf. Nat grinned to himself, thinking of Prince's laughter. "He must really shake the timbers of a ship!"

Captain Prince came on board, grim-jawed, frowning. His black eyes whipped a glance over the deck, seeing everything, looking at no one. Nat gulped. Something must be wrong. Had Prince had a quarrel with Mr. Derby, too?

Captain Prince spoke to Mr. Collins, his first mate — a tall, rangy man with a lean face and cool gray eyes. Soon came the hoarse cry, "All hands! Up anchor!" All

around him, men leaped to their duties, spreading sails, bracing the yards. Men walked round the capstan, leaning on the bars, heaving the anchor. Then, "Anchor's aweigh!" And the *Henry* was moving out to sea.

That evening in the middle of the dog watch, Captain Prince took his departure from Cape Ann. Navigation, Nat thought, was like surveying, all right. In surveying, you started from a known point and ran your lines by compass. In navigation, you took your departure from a known point, too, and steered your course by compass. But there the likeness ended.

Taking sights wouldn't be the same. In surveying, the earth was firm beneath your telescope. You could take all the time you wanted to check and recheck a sight. If you thought you had made a mistake, you could go back and do it over again. Here at sea, nothing would ever hold quite still. When you shot the sun at noon, you'd have one instant to get it and get it right.

And measuring your distances wouldn't be the same, either. In surveying, your chainmen could measure your distances for you. Here on the open sea, you'd measure your distance by checking your speed, and multiplying that by how long you had sailed that fast. "Many a man," Sam Smith had said, "sails halfway around the world by log, lead, and lookout." The log checked the speed, the lookout warned of dangers they could see, and the lead warned of dangers beneath the surface of the water — sudden shoals and reefs where they might go aground. He really knew a good bit about a ship, Nat thought, even though this was his first voyage.

Mr. Collins called all hands on deck to be divided into watches.

I know what the watches are, too, Nat thought. A watch is four hours: eight to midnight, midnight to four, and four to eight in the morning; then eight till noon, and noon till four. Then the next watch is the dog watch; it's divided into two watches; four to six and six to eight. Dividing the dog watch that way switches the hours of the watches for the next twenty-four, so that the same men don't stand two watches every night.

Mr. Collins was calling a man's name. The fellow nodded and moved to the larboard rail. Nat was thinking: I know about bells, too. One bell sounds the first half hour after the watch begins; two bells mark the next half hour, and so on until . . . Yes, I know a good bit about a ship. I know the —

Mr. Collins said, "Your choice, Mr. Bowditch. A man for your starboard watch."

Nat gulped and his brains began to spin. He had known he would stand watch, but he hadn't realized he'd command a watch. With his thoughts still in a whirl he said, "Chad Jensen."

Old Chad said, "Aye, aye sir!" and moved to the starboard side. Mr. Collins chose again. It was Nat's turn once more. "Dan Keeler."

He felt Mr. Collins' surprise. He was surprised at himself. Why had he chosen Dan Keeler? Dan was a troublemaker who'd been spread-eagled for twelve lashes many times.

Dan Keeler slewed a sidelong stare at Nat. "Aye, aye, sir," he rumbled. His glance seemed to say, You lubberly little runt!

When the crew had been divided into watches, Captain Prince came topside and stood on the quarter-deck, staring down at the men. He was still in a temper, Nat thought. Funny, what anger could do to a man. He looked ten years older than he had that day in Derby's office.

The captain began to speak. His words bit like the lash of a whip. It did not take him long to tell the men what he expected of them, and what would happen if they did not obey on the double. He finished, wheeled, and strode below.

They heaved the log and set the course. Eight bells. Mr. Collins said, "Lay below the larboard watch!"

And Nat stood on the deck of the *Henry*, in command of the first watch. With a hollow feeling where his stomach should have been he stared miserably about him. Old Chad Jensen was taking the first trick at the wheel. Thank goodness he knew someone. He went over and stood at Chad's shoulder, watching the compass

in the glow on the binnacle light. Good old Chad. He'd known him ever since his first days at the chandlery, when he used to drop in between voyages and spin yarns with Sam Smith.

Nat said, "You steer a straight course, Chad."

Chad's eyes did not move. His gaze was fixed on the compass. "Aye, aye, sir. Thank you, Mr. Bowditch."

The hollow feeling hit Nat's stomach again. Was he going to spend months — maybe a year — with men who acted as though they had never seen him before? He paced the deck and then stared miserably over the rail.

"Mr. Bowditch." Captain Prince was standing by him.

"Aye, aye, sir!"

"In any emergency, call me. Remember, a captain

always sleeps with one ear cocked." He wheeled and went below again.

His voice was still grim. He seemed to be speaking from the other side of a gulf that Nat could never cross. But Nat felt comforted.

At eight bells, when Mr. Collins relieved him, Nat stumbled below, surprised to find he was utterly exhausted. What had he done? Nothing. Just stayed on the alert, watching for emergencies. He threw himself into his bunk with his clothes on. "I know what that is, too," he muttered, "when you tumble in with your clothes on. You turn in *all standing*. Yes, I know a lot, I do!"

It seemed to him he had scarcely dozed off when confusion topside wakened him. He heard feet thudding across the deck, and men shouting. Someone banged on a hatch and bellowed, "All hands on deck!"

Nat stumbled topside. As he emerged from the hatchway, the wind almost took him off his feet. The *Henry* was rolling heavily, shipping water with every roll.

The rest of that night, and for six days and nights that followed, Nat found out what men meant by the Roaring Forties of the North Atlantic. Numb with weariness, he lived in wet clothes and ate cold food. It was bad enough on deck; it was worse below deck. The hatchways had to be closed, and below deck the air grew so foul that the very lanterns burned dim. Whenever Nat had to go below, the stench grabbed at his throat and turned his stomach. Why, he wondered, had he ever wanted to come to sea? Why did any man choose this life?

It was all right maybe for a man who became a cap-

tain — but what about men like Keeler and Jensen — who'd spent their lives in the fo'c'sle? Why would they live like this for salt beef, hardtack, and twelve dollars a month?

The sixth night, just before midnight, Nat went on deck for his watch. The storm had ended; the sky glittered with stars. Nat caught his breath and stared. No man, he thought, had ever seen stars until he had seen them from a ship in mid-ocean.

The next morning, just after seven bells of the forenoon watch, Captain Prince came on deck with his sextant, ready to shoot the sun. "Have you ever used a sextant, Mr. Bowditch?"

"Not at sea, sir. But I have one."

"Then get it."

"Aye, aye, sir!" Nat hurried below for his sextant and slate. If he could just do this smartly and well, maybe Prince wouldn't be so grim. He hurried topside, fumbled his sextant out of its case, and dropped the case. He flushed, and didn't pick it up. He leveled the sextant to catch the horizon, and started to bring the sun into focus.

Captain Prince drawled, "Don't you think you'll need a shade, Mr. Bowditch?"

Nat felt his ears burn. He fumbled the red glass into place. When the sun reached its zenith and stood still the fractional moment, Nat took his reading. He checked in the almanac. His slate pencil streaked through his figuring. Captain Prince stood watching him.

When Nat had finished, he said, "Hmmm. You are quick at figures, Mr. Bowditch. Well, we've got our latitude, all right. The longitude — that's something

else again. I wish chronometers weren't so infernally expensive."

Nat said, "How about a lunar, sir? Won't that give you your longitude?"

Prince shrugged. "Once in a blue moon you can get one, but by the time you've worked out all your computations, it's about two days later. You may find out where you were, but you'll never know where you are."

"I don't think the mathematics would take quite that long, sir," Nat said. "I'd like to try taking a lunar, first chance we have."

Prince shrugged again. "Go ahead. Be handy to know our longitude. If we could be sure." He didn't sound as though he thought much of the idea.

Nat checked his nautical almanac closely, hunting for the first night the moon promised to be in a good position for a lunar. That night he went on deck before the time for his watch, with his sextant.

Little Johnny, the cabin boy, joined him. "Mr. Bowditch, sir, would you tell me what you're going to do?"

"Of course, Johnny. I'm trying to find out a little more about where we are. We know our latitude — how far north of the equator we are. The trick is to find our longitude — how far east or west we are."

"East or west of where?" Johnny asked; then, hastily, "Sir?"

"That's a good question, Johnny. First, we have to pick a north-south line to be east or west of. And since we used to belong to England, we use the same line that the English use — the north-south line through London. We call it the meridian of London."

"But how can we ever figure how far west of London we are — when we're here — and London is away off somewhere else?"

"We have to figure that by time," Nat told him.

Johnny stared. "Time? Mr. Bowditch, sir, is that a joke?"

"No, Johnny. Every twenty-four hours, the earth turns around once. So the sun seems to be rising somewhere, every hour — even every minute. When it's sunrise in London, we know it's sunset halfway around the world. And, a fourth of the way around the world, it's midnight. If we had one of those fine ship's clocks called chronometers, we could use it to tell how far from London we are. We'd keep it set to London time. In the morning, when we checked our sunrise, we'd look at the clock and see what time it was in London, and we could figure how far from London we were, because we know how many miles the earth turns every hour."

"But we don't have one of those — uh — uh — special clocks, do we?"

"No, Johnny. So I'm going to check our position by the moon. You see, we know by the nautical almanac exactly where the moon will be — every hour, every minute, every second. And we know where a great many of the brightest stars will be. So, if we can catch the moon as it crosses in front of a certain star — we call it 'occulting' the star — we can figure how far away from London we are when we see it happen."

"That sounds easier," Johnny declared.

Nat grinned. "Most people don't think so. There's quite a little figuring to do. But the big problem is to catch the moon crossing in front of a star that is bright enough for us to still see the star when it's that close to the moon. There ought to be some better way to work a lunar,—but we don't have it—yet."

Johnny stared at Nat's sextant and sighed. "I wish some time I could look through a sextant."

"You can," Nat said. "The moon's going to be bright enough tonight for us to catch the horizon. I'll teach you to check Polaris — the North Star."

The next night, when Nat came topside before his watch, Keeler approached him. "Mr. Bowditch, sir, is it true that you let Johnny look through your sextant? Or was the little lubber lying to us?"

"He did try his hand with the sextant. Would you like to?"

"Me?" Keeler gulped. "You mean — *me*?"

"Why not?"

"But — but — nothing, sir."

That night Keeler had his turn at hearing about the moon and trying to check the angle of Polaris.

Then one evening during the dog watch, before the stars were visible, Nat leveled his sextant to catch the horizon. Johnny was at his elbow.

"Mr. Bowditch, sir, what are you doing now?"

"I'm sighting a star."

Johnny turned a puzzled glance to Nat. "But there aren't any stars."

"Yes, there are, Johnny. There are always stars. We just can't see them until it's dark enough for them to show. When you want to get an angle on a star, and we don't have bright moonlight, the problem is to get the horizon when it's light enough to see it, and to get the star when it's dark enough to see it. So I'm starting to check the star while I can still see the horizon. And I'm watching where I know the star will be when I can see it."

The men gathered round to listen. From that night on, the dog watch was Nat's busy time. Even Herbie, the huge Negro cook, wanted to hear Mr. Bowditch talk about the stars.

"Daggone," Herbie said, "it kind of picks a fellow up to think about the stars. Kind of makes you forget about soaking the salt beef till it's fitten to eat, and about smelling the bilge water." He shook his head and grinned. "Just think of me learning things! Me!"

"Of course you can learn," Nat told him. "Every one of you can learn."

But teaching them wasn't so easy. Time and again Nat explained something in the simplest words he could think of — only to see a blank look on the man's face. Time and again he wanted to shout, "Can't you see? Can't you understand anything?" But he always remembered Elizabeth Boardman and the parallel rulers. He

always remembered how she said, "Your brain — it's too fast. So you stumble on other people's dumbness — like a chair in the dark. And you want to kick something."

He would bite back his impatience. Slowly, carefully, he'd explain again — and again. At last he'd see the man's eyes brighten. He'd hear the happy, "Oh, yes! Simple, isn't it?" Nat would grin. "Yes — simple."

When he got back to his cabin, he would write down the explanation that had finally made sense to a man.

Just so I won't forget it, if I ever have to explain that again! he told himself. After three weeks, he had quite a stack of notes. He was making a new notebook, he

realized; a very different sort of notebook. All his other notebooks just said enough to explain things to him. But this notebook said everything he had to say to explain things to other men — to the men who sailed before the mast.

Weeks passed. Nat saw much more of the fo'c'sle and the cabin boy than he did of the captain, first mate, and their passenger. Captain Prince, Mr. Collins, and Monsieur Bonnefoy dined together. The second mate dined alone, after they had eaten. Nat didn't mind. At first he read at the table. But after he started teaching the men, he spent all his time at mess answering Johnny's questions. It helped — to explain things to Johnny. After he'd made Johnny understand, Nat didn't have to go over things so many times to make the men in the fo'c'sle understand.

One day Captain Prince called Nat to his cabin. The captain's grimness had not relaxed. "Tell me, Mr. Bowditch, just what are you trying to do with the men during the dog watch?"

"Teach them what they want to know, sir."

Captain Prince cocked an eyebrow. "And can learn?"

"They finally get it, sir," Nat told him, "if I just find the right way to explain it."

"But, Mr. Bowditch, why are you doing it?"

Nat was silent for a moment. "Maybe, sir, it's because I want to pay a debt I owe to the men who helped me; men like Sam Smith and Dr. Bentley and Dr. Prince and Nathan Read. Maybe that's why. Or maybe it's just because of the men. We have good men before the mast, Captain Prince. Every man of them could be a first mate — if he knew navigation."

Captain Prince muttered something under his breath. "An odd business!" he said. "But I've never had less trouble with a crew. Carry on, Mr. Bowditch."

"Aye, aye, sir."

Someone tapped on the door, and Monsieur Bonnefoy entered, smiling. "I have a confession to make, Captain Prince. I was eavesdropping through the skylight. Not by intention. I just happened to be there, and could not help hearing. Monsieur Bowditch — he has the magnificent spirit! It is worthy of the French Revolution! Liberty! Equality! Fraternity!"

Captain Prince roared, "What do you mean — the French Revolution? Who started this business of rebelling against kings? We did! We started it in 1775! It took you French until 1789 to get around to it!" Then, for the first time since the *Henry* had sailed, Nat saw a twinkle in Prince's eyes.

Monsieur Bonnefoy apologized. He was so embarrassed and he talked so fast that he started talking French. Without thinking, Nat answered him in French.

Bonnefoy beamed. "Monsieur! You speak French! Why didn't you tell me?"

"I — I — guess I just didn't think of it."

Captain Prince roared again. "So you didn't think of it? And here I've been expecting all along I'd have to have an interpreter in Bourbon! Have you any more tricks up your sleeve, Mr. Bowditch?"

"No, sir, I — I — don't think so, sir."

"No more languages?"

"Just — just — Latin, sir. I learned that to read Newton's *Principia*."

Prince mimicked him. "*Just Latin; to read Principia.* And you still think it's worth your time to teach those poor devils in the fo'c'sle?"

"Yes, sir, I do!" Nat snapped.

Captain Prince gave him a long, hard stare. "Carry on, Mr. Bowditch. That's all."

Almost three months out of Salem, the *Henry* reached the Cape of Good Hope, and ran into more bad weather. For three days and nights they fought head winds, trying to make their easting. Again the men lived in wet clothes and ate cold food, and turned to all standing, because they knew they'd be called out again soon by the bellow, "All hands on deck!"

"I wonder who named this the Cape of Good Hope?" Nat said.

Prince growled, "The Portygee explorers named it right — Cape *Tempestuoso* — the Cape of Storms. But I guess their king didn't like the sound of that. After all, he was interested in trade with the east. So he changed it to Cape of Good Hope."

Nat said, "I suppose Hope fits — in a way. You can always *hope* you'll get around it."

"*Double it, Mr. Bowditch!*" Prince roared. "You don't *get around* a cape! You *double it!* You — you — lubber!"

"Aye, aye, sir." Nat smiled to himself. He knew just how Prince felt. It was a relief to know he wasn't the only man who ever stumbled on someone's dumbness — like a chair in the dark — and wanted to kick something.

One night early in May Nat got a good lunar observation and worked out their longitude. He went to Prince's cabin. "According to my figures, sir, we're sixty-one miles east of our dead reckoning."

Captain Prince shook his head. "We couldn't have overrun our reckoning that much!"

"If my figures are right, sir, at our present speed, we'll sight Bourbon on the eighth."

Prince drawled, "So, Mr. Bowditch? I wouldn't put on my go-ashore clothes if I were you."

It was during Nat's watch early the morning of the eighth when he heard the lookout's singsong, "Land, ho-o-o-o-o-o!"

Captain Prince came on deck. He said, "Hmmmm . . ." He rubbed his chin and swept Nat with a sidelong glance. "I believe you can work a lunar, Mr. Bowditch."

"Of course," Nat said. "It's a simple matter of mathematics, sir."

Captain Prince said, "Hmmmm" again and returned to his cabin.

Nat stared across the water until the rugged peaks of Bourbon loomed on the horizon. Bourbon — where they'd sell their cargo for double its cost — or lose their shirts. For the first time in months, Nat thought of his venture. What would happen to his cargo of shoes in Bourbon? Would he win — or lose? He watched the ragged outline take shape in the mist. Bourbon . . .